TWELVE SECONDS

A historical short

Story Factory demonstration

Based on the documented flights of December 17, 1903. All dialogue and private exchanges are invented. Adapted from three National Park Service historical accounts. This is a compact demonstration, not a feature or biography.

FADE IN:

EXT. KILL DEVIL HILLS - MORNING

Wind combs the sand back over two footprints as quickly as the boots can make them.

WILBUR WRIGHT holds the edge of a wing. ORVILLE kneels at its skid. Both are dressed rather better than their surroundings deserve.

Orville draws a screw from his coat pocket. Sand comes with it.

WILBUR

That the last one?

ORVILLE

The last loose one.

Wilbur moves his grip. The fabric trembles, a small captive animal.

ORVILLE

Don’t let go.

WILBUR

I had understood that part.

Orville seats the screw. It turns once, then refuses. He backs it out, clears the sand on his cuff and starts again.

A gust lifts the wing until Wilbur has to put his weight on it. Orville stops working. Watches his brother’s shoes skid.

ORVILLE

We can wait.

WILBUR

We can.

Neither moves away. Orville finishes the screw.

EXT. LAUNCH RAIL - LATER

Volunteers from the lifesaving station take places around the machine. JOHN DANIELS stands at a camera already aimed down the rail.

Orville studies the narrow path ahead. The sand beyond it offers no reassurance.

Wilbur extends his hand. Orville shakes it.

The engine starts. Conversation disappears.

Orville settles into the cradle. Tests the controls once. Wilbur steadies the wing. They look at each other: the decision is no longer discussable.

Orville releases the restraint.

The machine travels down the rail. Wilbur runs beside it, hand raised to the wing. At first the distance between wood and sand is difficult to see.

Then there is distance.

Daniels presses the shutter.

Wilbur takes another stride with his hand still raised. The wing has left it behind.

The machine pitches. Orville moves, corrects too far, corrects again. The sand comes up. A short, ugly landing.

The engine stops.

Orville remains where he is. His hands still hold the controls.

Wilbur arrives, breathing hard. He touches the wing before he touches his brother.

WILBUR

Anything broken?

Orville looks down at himself, then at the skid.

ORVILLE

Which of us?

Wilbur helps him out.

EXT. SAND BESIDE THE RAIL - MOMENTS LATER

A measuring tape runs back toward the rail. Orville holds one end at the landing mark. Wilbur reads the distance.

WILBUR

A hundred and twenty feet.

Orville looks from the mark to the rail. From here it seems a terribly short trip for so much preparation.

ORVILLE

Time?

WILBUR

Twelve seconds.

A volunteer begins lifting the tape. Orville holds his end down a moment longer, preserving the line between the two places.

ORVILLE

All right.

He lets go. The tape disappears into its case.

Wilbur turns toward the machine. Orville walks with him.

EXT. LAUNCH RAIL AND SAND - DAY

The machine goes back to its beginning.

Wilbur takes the controls this time. Orville steadies the wing. The same preparations, done with less uncertainty and no less care.

A flight. A landing. Men carrying what cannot yet carry itself across sand.

Orville flies again. The distance lengthens. So does the walk back.

Before the fourth attempt, Wilbur checks the machine. Orville squats beside him, watching a fastening settle into place.

WILBUR

You needn’t watch every screw.

ORVILLE

Only the ones holding you up.

Wilbur gives it another quarter turn.

The fourth flight rises. Orville runs with it, then stops. He follows on foot as the flyer continues away.

It lasts long enough for waiting to become a different kind of work.

At the far end, Wilbur brings it down.

EXT. FOURTH LANDING SITE - LATER

The brothers stand beside the machine. They have measurements to write down and no suitable surface.

Orville braces a notebook against his thigh.

ORVILLE

Eight hundred and fifty-two.

He writes.

WILBUR

Fifty-nine seconds.

Orville writes that too. He checks the numbers against what they have just seen, as though one might invalidate the other.

ORVILLE

We should tell Father.

WILBUR

After lunch.

A gust takes the loose edge of the notebook. Orville clamps it shut.

The wing rises.

Wilbur grabs for it. Orville drops the notebook into his coat and catches a strut. The machine pulls both men sideways.

A shout from a volunteer. Hands reach for fabric and wood.

The flyer rolls. The brothers lose their grip.

A crack. Then several smaller sounds they know too well.

The machine lies still in the sand. The wind keeps working.

Wilbur approaches the damaged engine. Orville stays at the wing he could not hold.

ORVILLE

Can we repair it?

Wilbur doesn’t answer immediately. He examines the damage instead of offering comfort.

WILBUR

Not here.

Orville nods. He frees a strip of fabric caught under his boot. Puts it down carefully, out of the wind.

EXT. SAND BESIDE THE DAMAGED FLYER - AFTERNOON

The machine has been secured against another gust. Nothing in it moves now.

Orville opens the notebook. A grain of sand sits in the middle of the figures. He brushes it away without smearing them.

Wilbur joins him. Looks at the page.

WILBUR

That will sound small.

ORVILLE

It was small.

Wilbur looks back at the distance they crossed.

Orville tears a blank scrap from the rear of the notebook. Starts a message. Stops before the first word and reads the measurements again.

WILBUR

Tell him what happened.

Orville writes. Wilbur holds the scrap flat against the wind.

We cannot read the message. Only the two hands keeping the paper still.

Beyond them the damaged machine rests on the sand, and the empty air above it holds nothing at all.

FADE OUT.

THE END